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News

JD Spain, Sr. pledges to be voice for entire community on County Board

By **Scott McCaffrey**

Published December 16, 2024 at 9:45AM



JD Spain, Sr., at swearing-in ceremony (staff photo by Scott McCaffrey)

Incoming County Board member [JD Spain, Sr.](#), used his ceremonial [swearing-in ceremony](#) to promote the spirit of collaboration and community.

During the Dec. 14 ceremony, Spain — a Democrat — pledged to support a community “where everyone feels valued and safe.”

“There are so many folks in Arlington who feel their voices aren’t heard,” he said at the ceremony. “How do we move together? It’s not us vs. them.”

The ceremony was held in the board room of the Ellen Bozman Government Center, where Spain will spend many an hour over the coming four years.

Having bested three opponents in the [Nov. 5 general election](#), Spain, 52, will fill the seat of the departing Libby Garvey, who has held it for 12-plus years since a [2012 special-](#)

[election victory](#).

Spain's term officially starts Jan. 1, but members of the County Board — who for generations until recent years held an organizational meeting on New Year's Day — will not formally gather until Jan. 6.

Four generations of the Spain family were on hand for the ceremony, from his parents (who flew in from South Carolina) to his granddaughter.

Referencing his grandchild, Spain said his work would be designed to improve lives “for her generation and many more to come.”

The oath of office was administered by Clerk of the Circuit Court Paul Ferguson, after Kim Phillip, secretary of the Electoral Board, presented Spain with his formal commission.

Takis Karantonis, the Board's current vice chair and the likely chairman in 2025, delivered remarks on what traits make for a good elected official.

“Somebody who is a relationship-builder,” Karantonis said in listing them. “Somebody who is willing to listen and learn. A collaborator with a strategy and a purpose.”

Spain, a former head of the Arlington NAACP and career U.S. Marine Corps veteran, won the [springtime Democratic primary](#) in 2024 after having [fallen short in 2023](#).

In the [2024 general election](#), Spain defeated Republican Juan Carlos Fierro, Forward Party candidate Madison Granger and independent Audrey Clement. Because he received an [absolute majority](#) — 58% — of the vote, Arlington officials did not need to implement [ranked-choice machinery](#) to determine a victor.

During the ceremony, which drew a standing-room audience to the County Board room, Rev. DeLishia Davis of Calloway United Methodist Church urged Arlington residents to work together in building a stronger community.

“Arlington is at a very special place in history,” she said, urging those in attendance to serve as “a beacon of possibility, unity, progress and hope.”

In the audience were the the current holder of the seat Spain inherits on New Year's Day and her predecessor, both of whom first won it via special elections:

- Barbara Favola was elected in the fall of 1997 following the resignation of Board member James Hunter III due to illness.
- Garvey was elected in the spring of 2012 following Favola's [election to the Virginia Senate](#).

Among others on hand: U.S. Rep. Don Beyer (D) and a host of current and former elected officials, plus new School Board members Kathleen Clark and Zuraya Tapia-Hadley.

Among former elected officials on hand was John Vihstadt, the [last non-Democrat](#) to serve on the County Board with a term running from 2015-18.

Spain retired from the U.S. Marine Corps in 2016 with the rank of master gunnery sergeant (E9). He is the recipient of the [Legion of Merit](#), a military decoration denoting outstanding service and achievements to the nation.

Spain and his wife, Adriana, are residents of the Penrose neighborhood and have three adult children. The couple met when each was serving in the U.S. military; Spain will be the first military veteran serving on the Board in 15 years.

Spain and his four colleagues — Karantonis, Matt de Ferranti, Susan Cunningham and Maureen Coffey — will outline their goals for the coming year at the Board's organizational meeting on Jan. 6.

About the Author



Scott McCaffrey

A Northern Virginia native, Scott McCaffrey has four decades of reporting, editing and newsroom experience in the local area plus Florida, South Carolina and the eastern panhandle of West Virginia. He spent 26 years as editor of the Sun Gazette newspaper chain. For Local News Now, he covers government and civic issues in Arlington, Fairfax County and Falls Church.

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